coursera | MoMA
Modern Art & Ideas
Today's goal • 3/3 items
Module 1
Introduction to Modern Art & Ideas
Module 2
Places & Spaces
Introduction to Places & Spaces
Welcome to Module 2
Reading • 10 min
Places & Spaces
Video • 4 min
Real and Imaginary Places
How do artists choose to represent the world?
Reading • 20 min
Martin Wong. Stanton near Forsyth Street. 1983
Video • 1 min
Practical Scenario
Real-world application • 5 min
Zarina. Home is a Foreign Place. 1999
Video • 2 min
Experiencing a Place
How do artists capture the mood of a place?
Reading • 10 min
Claude Monet. Water Lilies. 1914-26
Video • 1 min
Practical Scenario
Real-world application • 5 min
Emeka Ogboh. Lagos State of Mind. 2017/2020
Video • 2 min
Reimagining a Place
How do artists reimagine architecture?
Reading • 10 min
Teddy Cruz, Fonna Forman. Manufactured Sites: A Housing Urbanism Made of Waste/Maquiladora, project (Model, 2005). 2005-2008
Video • 2 min
Carolina Caycedo. Spirals for Shared Dreams. 2022
Video • 4 min
Review & Reflect
Optional Readings & Resources
Reading • 10 min
Assessment: Places & Spaces
Dialogue • 15 min
Optional Prompts for Discussion & Reflection
Reading • 10 min
Module 3
Art & Identity
Introduction to Art & Identity
Welcome to Module 3
Reading • 10 min
Art & Identity
Video • 4 min
Identity & Portraiture
How do artists represent their sense of self?
Reading • 20 min
Henri Matisse. The Red Studio. 1911
Video • 2 min
Practical Scenario
Real-world application • 5 min
Frida Kahlo. Self-Portrait with Cropped Hair. 1940
Video • 1 min
Identity & Relationships
How do artists represent others?
Reading • 10 min
Catherine Opie. Being and Having. 1991
Video • 1 min
Practical Scenario
Real-world application • 5 min
Amira Virgil. The Melanin Pack for The Sims 4. 2016
Video • 2 min
Challenging Identity
How do artists challenge identity?
Reading • 10 min
Lorna Simpson. Wigs (Portfolio). 1994
Video • 2 min
Kay WalkingStick. You're an Indian? 1995
Video • 1 min
Review & Reflect
Optional Readings & Resources
Reading • 10 min
Assessment: Art & Identity
Dialogue • 15 min
Optional Prompts for Discussion & Reflection
Reading • 10 min
Optional Mid-Course Survey
Reading • 5 min
Module 4
Transforming Everyday Objects
Module 5
Module 5: Art & Society
Module 6
Course Conclusion

How do artists challenge identity?

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Lynn Hershman Leeson. *Roberta's Construction Chart #2*. 1976. Chromogenic print, printed 2003. 22 15/16 × 29 5/8" (58.3 × 75.3 cm). The Modern Women's Fund. © 2025 Lynn Hershman

Lynn Hershman Leeson created and assumed the identity of a "simulated person" named Roberta Breitmore for several years in 1970s San Francisco. The artist later described Roberta as "an abstract vehicle that could interact with the world." Embodying this character in reality required more than cosmetic changes, like wearing a wig or makeup; Roberta had her own handwriting and therapist, and possessed real credit cards and a driver's license. In *Roberta's Construction Chart #2*, Hershman Leeson critically plays with stereotypical beauty ideals, transforming a photograph of herself as Roberta through annotations and drawn lines of "suggested alterations" inspired by magazine images.





Howardena Pindell. *Free, White and 21*. 1980. Video (color, sound), 12:15 min. The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of Jerry I. Speyer and Katherine G. Farley, Anna Marie and Robert F. Shapiro, and Marie-Josée and Henry R. Kravis. © 2016 Howardena Pindell. Courtesy of the artist and The Kitchen, New York

Born in Philadelphia in 1943, Howardena Pindell grew up when the South was still lawfully segregated and racism was rampant nationwide. She was 21 when the Civil Rights Act passed in 1964. In 1980, she set up a video camera in her apartment, focused it on herself, and made *Free, White and 21*, a deadpan accounting of the racism she experienced coming of age as a Black woman in America.

She emphasizes the stark divide between Black and white Americans by appearing as both herself and as a white woman in this video. It opens with a shot of the artist in whiteface and wearing a blond wig, in the guise of a white woman from the 1950s or 60s. This character is the free, white, 21-year-old to which its title refers, who appears throughout the video discounting Pindell's experiences with statements like, "you won't exist until we validate you."

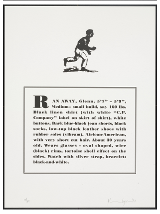


Milagros de la Torre. *Under the Black Sun*. 1991-93. Inkjet prints, printed 2004, 58 × 98" (147.3 × 248.9 cm). Acquired through the generosity of Eduardo Hochschild and Ramiro Ortiz Mayorga through the Latin American and Caribbean Fund. © 2024 Milagros de la Torre

Milagros de la Torre's series *Under The Black Sun* is made up of 10 photographs in their negative stage and tinted with a red dye. The portrait series was made in Cusco, Peru, where the artist used a technique practiced by street photographers in taking instant passport ID photos. The photographers would retouch the paper negative with red dye—a diluted monochrome, which is also used as a disinfectant for cuts and bruises—that worked as a filter that made the subject appear as if they had fairer skin.

De la Torre would apply the red dye, but stop midway through developing the photograph so that the liquid clings to the skin of the portrait's subject. By subverting the skin lightening process, de la Torre seeks to undermine standards set by colonialism, in which "skin tone served as a racial and social identifier." She hopes her portrait series encourages us to "engage with the questions of identity, the reasons why we choose to represent ourselves a certain way, and the effort that goes in getting that ideal image of who we wish to be."





Glenn Ligon. *Untitled*, from *Runaways*. 1993. One from a portfolio of 10 lithographs, composition (irreg.): 12 9/16 x 8 15/16" (31.9 x 22.7 cm); sheet: 16 x 12" (40.7 x 30.5 cm). Publisher: Max Protech Gallery, New York. Printer: Burnet Editions, New York. The Museum of Modern Art, New York. The Ralph E. Shikes Fund. © 2016 Glenn Ligon

In his series *Untitled (Runaways)*, Glenn Ligon explores how Black identity in the United States has been shaped by the history of slavery. He has said, "If I have a well to dip into, it's filled with almost four hundred years worth of permutations of what Blackness has meant and speculations on what it might mean in the future."

Ligon began this series by asking 10 friends to imagine that he was missing and to provide descriptions that would help people find him. He included their portrayals in lithographs styled after two opposing historical documents: their layout mimics that of runaway slave posters from the early 17th to mid-19th centuries, while their illustrations and typeface come from 19th-century abolitionist publications. These descriptions also recall contemporary "Wanted" posters for suspected criminals, suggesting that the language of slavery aligns with the stereotyping and racial prejudice that remains a part of the justice system today.



Mona Hatoum. *Routes V*. 2002. Colored ink and gouache on five maps; a: gouache on map; b: gouache on map; c: colored ink on map; d: gouache on map; e: colored ink on map, installation: 35 1/2 x 42 x 1" (90.2 x 106.7 x 2.5 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. The Judith Rothschild Foundation Contemporary Drawings Collection Gift. © 2016 Mona Hatoum

Mona Hatoum's work is shaped by her own experience of displacement—and the sense of rootlessness and freedom that it engendered in her. She bases her work on "a feeling of wanting to be free of all those restrictions…that are always put on people, so I can be whatever I want to be."

Born to Palestinian parents in Beirut, Hatoum was on a trip to London in 1975 when the Lebanese Civil War began, preventing her from returning home. She decided to stay on, and still lives and works there today. "The nomadic existence suits me fine," she says, "because I do not expect myself to identify completely with any one place." She made *Routes V* out of five maps advertising flights offered by different airline companies. Hatoum augmented the webbed patterns of the existing flight routes crisscrossing the maps with ink and gouache, creating abstract designs that she calls "routes for the rootless."

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